

Miners Fail To Cash In On Upset

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Bats were kicked around, gloves crashed up against the wall in the dugout and heads hung low as silence suddenly overtook what seemed to be a celebration only moments earlier.

For one brief moment, the University of Texas at El Paso's baseball season was about to mean something to the players.

Nine consecutive times in Western Athletic Conference action, the Miners had fallen by the wayside — usually by embarrassing scores.

Friday was different and UTEP pitcher Jerry Walker will attest to that. For eight innings at Dudley Field, the sophomore from Odessa baffled Arizona's Wildcats who were last season's National Collegiate Athletic Association champions.

At the same time, the Miners had escaped with an unearned run in the sixth as Wes Zotz reached second base when Arizona leftfielder Jim Morley dropped a fly ball and later scored on Terry Dillingham's base hit.

Heading into the ninth, enthusiasm rumbled through UTEP's dugout. Never before had the Miners been so close to

knocking off a powerful opponent such as Arizona.

With Walker still on the mound, Arizona's Jim Morley stopped a few Miner heart beats with a blast deep to almost straightaway center field only to have UTEP's Bob Alsup spear the ball with his glove fully extended before he crashed into the fence.

Walker made a mistake though. He walked Rick McConnell and served up two balls to Steve Jaso which prompted Coach Andy Cohen to send an SOS message to Mike Rima in the bullpen.

Rima forced Jaso to slam a line drive to teammate Brad George up against the fence in left for the second out.

But disaster suddenly struck. On a two-two pitch, Glenn Wendt singled to right followed by a run-scoring hit between third and short by Les Pearsey to tie the score. A routine grounder to shortstop Rusty Kennedy by Arizona's Lynn Garrett escaped Kennedy's glove for an error which allowed another run to score and the final outcome read 2-1 Arizona.

The Miners were not without a final chance in the bottom of the frame as Sal Flores singled to lead off the inning

followed by a sacrifice bunt by Alsup which sent pinch-runner Keith Cooper to second.

Cooper remained at second on an infield ground out by Orlando Cordova and the game quickly ended when Cooper was caught napping off second.

"We ain't gonna come any closer to winning," said Cohen following UTEP's 10th straight WAC loss and 18th of the season compared to 23 victories. "We gave them a hell of a battle and we should have won that game."

"Walker pitched the greatest game of his career. He wasn't forcing himself. It's just that our ace reliever didn't get them out. I feel sorry for our boys because they wanted this one bad."

Walker struck out only one batter while walking five but allowed only five hits through eight and one third innings of mound duty, forcing Arizona to ground out a dozen times.

Arizona's victory kept the Wildcats atop the WAC Southern Division with an 8-2 record while improving their season record to 35-20.

The two teams conclude the three-game series at 11 a.m. Saturday at Dudley field with a doubleheader.